

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

The Division of Responsibility in Feeding

Calmer mealtimes, less pressure · Ages 2–4

Feeding battles leave everyone stressed. The 'division of responsibility' gives parents and children each a clear job, and takes the pressure off.

What the research found

- ○ Children rewarded for cleaning their plates became less responsive to their own fullness cues (Birch et al., 1987).
- ○ Dietitian Ellyn Satter's 'division of responsibility' is widely used by feeding specialists to reduce mealtime conflict.

Your job (parent)

- ○ Decide what food is served
- ○ Decide when meals and snacks happen (about every 2–3 hours)
- ○ Decide where: at the table, together, without screens
- ○ Include at least one food your child usually eats

Their job (child)

- ○ Decide whether to eat
- ○ Decide how much to eat

Things to avoid

- ○ “One more bite” and bribing with dessert
- ○ Praising a clean plate
- ○ Cooking a separate meal every time they refuse

Things that help

- ○ Small portions, seconds allowed (less waste, too)
- ○ Eating together and enjoying your own food
- ○ Offering new foods many times, without pressure
- ○ Ending the meal calmly when they're done

When to check

If your child is losing weight, has very few accepted foods, or meals involve choking or vomiting, speak to your paediatrician.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Birch, L. L., McPhee, L., Shoba, B. C., Steinberg, L., & Krehbiel, R. (1987). 'Clean up your plate': Effects of child feeding practices on the conditioning of meal size. Learning and Motivation, 18(3), 301–317.
Ellyn Satter Institute: The Division of Responsibility in Feeding. · https://www.ellynsatterinstitute.org/

General information, not medical advice.